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The RRB ALP 2026 CBT-1 Countdown Playbook

39 days to the Assistant Loco Pilot exam. Every date, rule and marking scheme decoded from the official CEN No. 01/2026 - plus the master plan that turns 8.4 lakh rivals into a shortlist.

CEN 01/2026 | 11,127 POSTS | CBT-1: 3-5 NOVEMBER 2026

Built from official Railway Recruitment Board notifications, the 21 September 2026 exam-schedule notice and official zone-wise CBT-1 cutoff data from the previous recruitment cycle.

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How to use this playbook

Read sections 1 to 5 once, today. They tell you exactly what the exam is, what the competition looks like and what score you are chasing. Then live inside sections 6 to 11 - the playbooks and the day-by-day plan - until your exam date. Section 12 tells you what to do the moment you walk out of the test centre, and section 13 is your final-week runbook. Every fact in this guide is drawn from the official CEN No. 01/2026, the RRB exam-schedule notice dated 21 September 2026 and official RRB result data; sources are listed on the last page.

1. The situation: 8.4 lakh candidates, 39 days

On 21 September 2026, the Railway Recruitment Boards published the notice that lakhs of candidates had been waiting for: the first-stage Computer Based Test (CBT-1) for Assistant Loco Pilot recruitment against CEN No. 01/2026 will run from 3 to 5 November 2026. If you are one of the 8,40,944 applicants, your exam is 39 days away.

The arithmetic of this recruitment is brutal but worth staring at once. There are 11,127 posts and roughly 8.4 lakh accepted applications - about 76 candidates for every seat. The CBT-1 does not select anyone. It screens: only about 15 times the vacancies, roughly 1.67 lakh candidates, move to CBT-2 in each zone. Your first job is simply to be inside that shortlist, and the entry ticket is a strong 75-question, 60-minute test.

11,127 POSTS Assistant Loco Pilot posts across all zones, CEN 01/2026	8,40,944 APPLICANTS About 76 candidates competing for every single seat	3-5 Nov CBT-1 DATES Three-day exam window; you get one date and one shift	39 DAYS RUNWAY Full days left from 25 September to your earliest exam date
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Thirty-nine days is not a lot, but it is enough - if you spend them correctly. This playbook is built for exactly that. It assumes you have some background in the syllabus (most ALP aspirants have prepared for at least one railway or SSC exam before) and it focuses on three things: knowing the official rules cold so nothing surprises you, converting the three CBT-1 sections into reliable marks, and running a disciplined countdown instead of a panic.

One more thing before anything else. The RRB has said the dates are tentative. The exam window can shift by a few days for technical reasons. Everything in this plan is anchored to the earliest published date - 3 November - so you are ready even if your shift lands on day one. Check your chosen RRB's website and rrbapply.gov.in at least twice a week from now on, and trust nothing that is not published there.

Where the posts are: a zone-wise snapshot

You compete inside your chosen RRB's pool, so its post count sets your odds. Selected zone-wise vacancies under CEN 01/2026 (the complete railway-wise list is Annexure-B of the CEN):

RRB - railway zone	Posts	RRB - railway zone	Posts
Mumbai - Central	1,078	Guwahati - NFR	676
Bhubaneswar - ECoR	801	Kolkata - SER	497
Ajmer - NWR	600	Prayagraj - NCR	457
Jammu - NR	400	Bhopal - WCR	423
Kolkata - ER	344	Bilaspur - CR	322
Malda - SER	289	Malda - ER	270
Ajmer - WCR	118	Bengaluru - SWR	200
Chandigarh - NR	187	Chennai - SR	186
Prayagraj - NR	153	Ahmedabad - WR	147
Bilaspur - SECR	200	Gorakhpur - NER	105

Source: CEN No. 01/2026 vacancy details as published with the notification; vacancies are provisional.

Who this recruitment is for

The eligibility bar tells you who you are competing with. Assistant Loco Pilot requires matriculation plus an ITI in one of the listed trades (Fitter, Electrician, Instrument Mechanic, Electronics Mechanic, Mechanic Motor Vehicle, Mechanic Diesel, Turner, Machinist, Wireman, Refrigeration and Air-conditioning Mechanic and others), or matriculation plus a completed Act Apprenticeship in one of those trades, or matriculation plus a three-year diploma in Mechanical, Electrical, Electronics or Automobile Engineering - with an engineering degree in those disciplines accepted in place of the diploma. Age is reckoned as 18 to 30 years as on 1 July 2026, with relaxations for reserved categories, ex-servicemen and railway staff as detailed in the CEN.

Two consequences follow. First, most of your rivals are hands-on technical people - fitters, electricians, workshop apprentices and fresh diploma holders - which is why the General Science and Reasoning sections decide more than heavy mathematics. Second, because the entry bar is 10th-plus-ITI, the paper stays anchored at 10th-standard difficulty. Depth is not your problem in CBT-1. Speed and accuracy are.

2. The official timeline, verified

Here is the complete, verified calendar of this recruitment, from the indicative notice in March to the CBT-1 window in November. Every date below comes from the official CEN No. 01/2026 or the RRB notice dated 21 September 2026.

Event	Date
Indicative notice in Employment News	21 March 2026
Detailed CEN No. 01/2026 published on RRB websites	14 May 2026
Online application window	15 May - 14 June 2026 (23:59 hrs)
Application fee payment window	till 16 June 2026 (23:59 hrs)
Application modification window	17 - 26 June 2026
CBT-1 exam schedule notice	21 September 2026
Exam city and date intimation link	About 10 days before your exam date (around 24-27 October)
SC/ST travel authority download	With the exam city link, about 10 days before the exam
E-call letter (admit card) download	About 4 days before your exam date (around 30 October - 2 November)
CBT-1 exam window	3 - 5 November 2026 (tentative; one date and shift per candidate)
CBT-2 shortlisting ratio	About 15 times the vacancies, RRB-wise and community-wise
CBAT shortlisting ratio	About 8 times the vacancies, for CBAT-qualified candidates

Source: CEN No. 01/2026 and RRB CBT-1 schedule notice dated 21.09.2026.

If you have not done it yet, log in to rrbapply.gov.in and check your application status: accepted forms show as provisionally accepted (or conditionally accepted, with a reason and a fix listed), and rejected forms show the ground. A conditional acceptance must be resolved before the exam - log in, read the reason, and follow the instruction given there. This is also where you complete your Aadhaar linking if the portal asks for it, since entry to the exam centre runs on Aadhaar-based biometric authentication.

The two downloads that decide your October

Around 24-27 October, the exam city and date link goes live on the websites of all RRBs. That is when you learn which city and which of the three exam days is yours. Around four days before that date, the e-call letter opens. Do not book non-refundable travel before the city link is out, and do not wait for the last day to download the call letter - servers get slow when lakhs of candidates hit them at once.

Keep your registration number, date of birth and the mobile number linked to your application safe and reachable. All communication from the RRB - city intimation, call letter, results - arrives through the RRB websites, SMS and email, never by post.

A note on the application fee, in case you are still tracking it: the fee was Rs. 500 for general candidates and Rs. 250 for SC, ST, ex-servicemen, female, transgender, minority and economically backward class candidates. Rs. 400 of the general fee, and the full concession fee, is refunded after you appear in CBT-1, minus bank charges - one more reason to simply show up and give the exam your best hour, whatever your preparation state.

3. The selection pipeline: five gates to the loco cab

Assistant Loco Pilot selection has five stages. You are preparing for the first one, but you should understand all five, because two of them - the trade paper and the medical - end more candidatures than candidates expect.

Stage	What it is	What it decides
1. CBT-1	75 questions, 60 minutes, three sections. Screening only - its marks are not counted in the final panel.	Who is shortlisted (about 15x vacancies per RRB) for CBT-2
2. CBT-2	Part A: 100 questions in 90 minutes (Maths, Reasoning, Basic Science and Engineering). Part B: 75 questions in 60 minutes from your ITI trade or engineering discipline.	Part A carries 50% of the final merit. Part B is qualifying: 35% for every candidate, no relaxation
3. CBAT	Computer Based Aptitude Test - five test batteries covering memory, following directions, depth perception, concentration and perceptual speed.	Qualifying: minimum T-score of 42 in each battery. Carries the other 50% of the final merit
4. Document Verification	Original certificates checked against the application.	Candidature stands or falls on genuine, matching documents
5. Medical Examination	A-1 medical standard - the strictest railway category, demanding the highest visual acuity, tested for colour and night vision.	Final fitness for running duty. No alternate appointment is offered if found unsuitable

Source: CEN No. 01/2026.

What the 50:50 merit formula means for you

The final merit list is built half from CBT-2 Part A and half from the CBAT score - a change from the older 70:30 split. Practically: you cannot bank on the written score alone, and you cannot out-psycho-test a weak Part A. But none of that matters in November. Everything after CBT-1 is a later war. Clear CBT-1 well, and you get three more months to prepare for the rest.

The post itself is worth the fight. Assistant Loco Pilot sits in Pay Level-2 of the 7th CPC pay matrix with initial basic pay of Rs. 19,900, plus running allowances that most railway posts do not carry. It is a running-duty, safety-critical job - which is exactly why the medical standard is A-1 and the aptitude test exists. If you wear glasses, get an honest eye check now rather than after you have cleared three written stages.

A fact most candidates learn too late

ALP is classified as not suitable for PwBD candidates in the CEN's post parameters, and candidates found medically unsuitable for ALP are not given an alternate post. If vision or colour perception could be an issue, verify your status against the A-1 standard before investing the next five months in this recruitment.

4. The CBT-1 paper, decoded

The CBT-1 pattern under CEN No. 01/2026 is short and sharp. Learn every cell of this table - each one changes how you should play the paper.

Section	Questions	Marks
Mathematics	20	20
General Intelligence and Reasoning	25	25
General Science (10th standard level)	30	30
Total	75	75

Source: CEN No. 01/2026; section-wise distribution as reported after the 21 September 2026 notice.

The key change from the 2024 cycle: General Awareness is no longer part of CBT-1. The current paper tests only Mathematics, Reasoning and General Science, all at roughly the 10th-standard level. That is why this playbook spends its pages on those three sections and nowhere else. The paper is available in English, Hindi and the regional languages listed in the CEN; you answer in the language you chose in your application.

The four rules of the paper

- **60 minutes for 75 questions.** That is 48 seconds per question on average. The paper is a speed test first, a knowledge test second.
- **Plus one, minus one-third.** Every correct answer earns 1 mark; every wrong answer burns one-third of a mark. Unattempted questions score zero.
- **Normalization applies.** The exam runs across multiple shifts, so RRB statistically normalizes marks across shifts. You are compared fairly against your own shift, not against a rumoured 'easy shift'.
- **Minimum qualifying marks.** UR and EWS need 40%, OBC (NCL) and SC need 30%, ST needs 25% - but clearing this bar alone will not shortlist you; the cutoff does that.

Category	Minimum qualifying percentage	Out of 75 marks
UR and EWS	40%	30.00
OBC (NCL) and SC	30%	22.50
ST	25%	18.75

Source: CEN No. 01/2026. Qualifying marks are the floor, not the target - last cycle's cutoffs were far higher.

The negative-marking math every candidate should do once

The one-third penalty is calibrated so that blind guessing is worthless. With four options, a blind guess is right a quarter of the time: expected gain is 0.25 marks and expected penalty is 0.75 times one-third, which is also 0.25 marks. Net expected value of pure guessing: zero. Guessing only pays when you can eliminate two options - then your expected value turns positive.

Worked example: accuracy beats attempts

Candidate A races through 70 questions, gets 58 right and 12 wrong: score = $58 - (12 \times 1/3) = 54.00$. Candidate B attempts 60, gets 57 right, 3 wrong: score = $57 - 1 = 56.00$. Candidate B attempted ten fewer questions and still finished two marks ahead. At these cutoffs - where last cycle's zone cutoffs ran from the 40s to above 70 - two marks can be the distance between CBT-2 and the exit.

Here is the practical conclusion for your 60 minutes: attempt everything you know, attempt everything you can narrow to two options, and leave truly blind guesses alone. A well-prepared candidate should be attempting 60 to 68 questions with at least 90% accuracy - a raw score comfortably above 55.

How normalization actually treats you

Because the paper runs across many shifts over three days, raw scores are converted to normalized marks using a statistical process that accounts for shift-to-shift difficulty differences, and shortlisting happens on those normalized marks. You do not need the formula; you need the implications. One: an afternoon shift is not a death sentence. Two: comparing your mock scores with a friend in a different shift is meaningless. Three: aim well past the historical cutoff of your zone, so that a point or two of normalization noise cannot touch you. And four: never leave a question-paper discussion group feeling finished or finished-off - the normalizer has not done its work yet.

5. What score do you actually need?

CBT-1 cutoffs are set RRB-wise and community-wise, on normalized marks, at whatever level shortlists about 15 candidates per vacancy in that zone. Nobody can predict the 2026 cutoff, but the previous cycle (CEN 01/2024, exam November 2024) is the best available evidence of how zones behave. Study the UR cutoffs from that cycle:

RRB zone (UR cutoff, out of 75)	UR	OBC	SC	ST	EWS
Muzaffarpur	72.09	66.26	50.45	32.11	56.30
Patna	67.59	62.71	49.65	25.23	55.43
Gorakhpur	63.90	51.37	44.13	25.24	40.09
Kolkata	63.44	46.82	45.73	34.71	40.05
Malda	63.06	55.98	41.57	39.81	49.80
Ranchi	61.61	48.47	39.67	31.05	40.44
Bhubaneswar	60.98	50.83	42.46	44.08	40.13
Guwahati	59.91	49.18	37.48	26.24	40.11
Prayagraj	59.58	54.51	48.81	25.00	40.09
Bengaluru	58.49	47.16	42.11	32.24	40.07
Bilaspur	58.41	46.14	40.68	30.39	40.00
Mumbai	57.17	44.08	36.68	30.48	40.17
Secunderabad	56.20	43.81	38.27	32.32	40.09
Ahmedabad	54.54	41.38	36.01	28.67	40.01
Ajmer	54.33	39.27	36.19	27.99	40.18
Jammu	52.53	38.15	35.49	25.03	41.68
Chennai	49.51	39.35	34.42	25.07	40.15
Thiruvananthapuram	48.93	48.90	30.06	31.49	40.09
Bhopal	45.53	38.90	31.53	27.59	40.02

RRB zone (UR cutoff, out of 75)	UR	OBC	SC	ST	EWS
Chandigarh	40.09	30.01	30.01	25.02	n/a

Source: official RRB zone-wise CBT-1 results for CEN 01/2024, published 26 February 2025 (normalized marks out of 75).

Read that table as bands, not exact numbers. In seven of twenty zones, the UR cutoff was above 60; in the toughest - Muzaffarpur and Patna - it crossed 67. Only two zones let UR candidates through in the low 40s. Two honest warnings: the 2024 paper included a General Awareness section that no longer exists, and cutoffs move with vacancy counts and applicant quality every cycle. Treat these as a floor for ambition, not a promise.

Your target bands

Raw score (out of 75)	What it would have meant in the 2024-25 cycle
Below 40	Clears the UR qualifying bar but shortlists nowhere. Not enough.
45 - 52	Alive in roughly half the zones, comfortable in none.
55 - 60	Competitive in most zones; still risky in the Bihar-Bengal cluster.
62 - 68	Clears every zone's UR cutoff from the last cycle with room to spare.
Above 68	Safe everywhere the last cycle is any guide.

Plan for the worst zone, not the best. Set your personal target at 62 or higher - that means roughly 14 out of 20 in Mathematics, 20 out of 25 in Reasoning and 27 out of 30 in General Science, with accuracy above 90%. Those three numbers, section by section, are what the rest of this playbook is engineered to produce.

Why the Bihar zones run hot

Zones like Muzaffarpur and Patna consistently post the highest ALP cutoffs in the country because applications per post are heaviest there and the applicant pool is intensely prepared. If you applied to one of these zones, your 62-target needs to become a 68-target. The consolation: normalization and RRB-wise shortlisting mean you are only competing within your own zone's pool - a Patna cutoff of 67.59 last cycle was still just 15 candidates per vacancy being pulled through.

6. The Mathematics playbook

Twenty questions, twenty marks, and the section where the 48-second clock bites hardest. The official syllabus from the CEN is short enough to memorise:

Official CBT-1 Mathematics syllabus (CEN 01/2026, verbatim topics)

Number system, BODMAS, Decimals, Fractions, LCM, HCF, Ratio and Proportion, Percentages, Mensuration, Time and Work; Time and Distance, Simple and Compound Interest, Profit and Loss, Algebra, Geometry and Trigonometry, Elementary Statistics, Square Root, Age Calculations, Calendar and Clock, Pipes and Cistern.

That is not a university syllabus - it is the arithmetic of Classes 8 to 10. The section rewards two things: flawless basics (fractions, percentages, tables up to 20) and pattern recognition from volume practice. Sort the syllabus into tiers by how often questions appear and how quickly they can be solved:

Tier	Topics	Why this tier
Tier 1 - daily	Percentages, ratio and proportion, profit and loss, SI and CI, time and work, time-speed-distance	Highest frequency and the fastest marks once techniques are automatic
Tier 2 - every other day	Number system, LCM and HCF, BODMAS, fractions, squares and square roots, averages and elementary statistics, mensuration	Steady scorers; depend on formulas you already half-know
Tier 3 - weekly	Age calculations, calendar and clock, pipes and cisterns, algebra, geometry and trigonometry basics	Lower frequency but very formula-driven; a weekend each makes them safe

Speed techniques that actually appear in this paper

Below are worked examples at the difficulty the paper really tests. Do not just read them - redo each one on paper until it takes under 45 seconds.

BODMAS (typical difficulty)

$24 / 4 \times 3 + (7 - 3)^2 = ?$ Work brackets first: $(7-3) = 4$, squared = 16. Then division and multiplication, left to right: $24/4 = 6$; $6 \times 3 = 18$. Add: $18 + 16 = 34$. The trap is doing 4×3 before $24 / 4$ - multiplication and division are equal rank, so you go left to right.

Percentages via fractions

A salary of Rs. 28,000 rises by 15%. $15\% = 3/20$, so the rise is $28,000 \times 3/20 = \text{Rs. } 4,200$ and the new salary is Rs. **32,200**. Memorise fraction equivalents - $1/8 = 12.5\%$, $1/6 = 16.67\%$, $3/8 = 37.5\%$ - and percentage questions become one-line mental arithmetic.

Profit and loss

A shopkeeper buys a cycle for Rs. 2,400 and marks it 25% above cost: marked price = $2,400 \times 1.25 = \text{Rs. } 3,000$. He allows a 10% discount: selling price = $3,000 \times 0.9 = \text{Rs. } 2,700$. Profit = 300 on a cost of 2,400 = **12.5%**. Chain the percentages through the base each time - the single most common error in this topic is taking the second percentage on the wrong base.

Time and work

A finishes a job in 12 days, B in 18 days. Together they do $1/12 + 1/18 = 3/36 + 2/36 = 5/36$ of the job per day, so the whole job takes $36/5 = \mathbf{7.2 \text{ days}}$ (7 days 4.8 hours). Standard LCM method: take capacity = $\text{LCM}(12,18) = 36$ units; A does 3 units/day, B does 2; together 5 units/day; $36/5 = 7.2$ days.

Simple vs compound interest

Rs. 15,000 at 8% for 3 years: $SI = 15000 \times 8 \times 3/100 = \text{Rs. } 3,600$. The same at compound interest compounds to $15000 \times 1.08^3 = \text{Rs. } 18,895.70$, i.e. interest **Rs. 3,895.70**. For 2 years there is a shortcut: $CI - SI = P(r/100)^2$; at Rs. 10,000 and 10% that is $10000 \times 0.01 = \text{Rs. } 100$ - which is why CI of Rs. 10,000 at 10% for 2 years is Rs. 2,100 while SI is Rs. 2,000.

Pipes and cisterns

A pipe fills a tank in 20 minutes; a leak empties it in 30 minutes. Net rate = $1/20 - 1/30 = 3/60 - 2/60 = 1/60$ per minute, so the tank fills in **60 minutes**. Identical machinery to time-and-work; only the sign of the leak changes.

Trains and speed

A 240 m train crosses a pole at 72 km/h. Convert: $72 \text{ km/h} = 72 \times 5/18 = 20 \text{ m/s}$. Crossing a pole means covering its own length: $240/20 = \textbf{12 seconds}$. Every train question hides one conversion ($\times 5/18$ or $\times 18/5$) and one decision (pole = own length; platform = own length + platform length).

Boats and streams

A boat goes 12 km/h in still water and the stream runs 4 km/h. Downstream speed = 16, upstream = 8. If the boat goes 32 km downstream and 32 km back, total time = $32/16 + 32/8 = 2 + 4 = \textbf{6 hours}$. Note the asymmetry: the current hurts you for longer than it helps - which is why average speed for the round trip is $64/6 = 10.67 \text{ km/h}$, below the still-water speed.

Mensuration where 22/7 is enough

Area of a circle of radius 7 cm = $22/7 \times 7 \times 7 = \textbf{154 cm}^2$. A cylinder of radius 7 cm and height 10 cm: volume = $22/7 \times 49 \times 10 = \textbf{1,540 cm}^3$; curved surface = $2 \times 22/7 \times 7 \times 10 = \textbf{440 cm}^2$. Keep a single card with: circle area and circumference, triangle ($1/2 \times \text{base} \times \text{height}$, Heron for sides), cuboid, cylinder, cone and sphere. Roughly a third of mensuration questions in this paper are formula-substitution at exactly this level.

Ratio and ages

Divide Rs. 4,200 in 3:4 - one part is $4,200/7 = 600$, so the shares are Rs. **1,800** and Rs. **2,400**. Ages: a father is 3x his son's age; in 12 years he will be 2x. Set $F = 3S$ and $F + 12 = 2(S + 12)$: $3S + 12 = 2S + 24$, so $S = \textbf{12}$ and $F = \textbf{36}$. Both are the same skill: convert a sentence into one equation in one unknown.

LCM and HCF

Two bells ring every 12 and 18 minutes; they ring together at 8:00 a.m. Next together = $\text{LCM}(12,18) = \textbf{36 minutes later, 8:36 a.m.}$ The largest number dividing both 84 and 126 is $\text{HCF} = \textbf{42}$. Two habits: prime-factorise quickly ($84 = 2^2 \times 3 \times 7$; $126 = 2 \times 3^2 \times 7$), and remember $\text{HCF} \times \text{LCM} = \text{product of the two numbers}$ - the fastest check that you did not slip.

For elementary statistics, know mean, median and mode cold and be able to read a small data set fast: for 12, 15, 11, 18, 14 the mean is 14 and the median is 14. Data interpretation questions in this paper are small - a five-row table or a simple bar chart - so practise reading the axes first and computing only what the options need.

Data interpretation, the five-question gift

Monday to Friday, a workshop produces 120, 150, 135, 180 and 165 units. Average daily production: $(120+150+135+180+165)/5 = 750/5 = \mathbf{150 \text{ units}}$. Percentage increase from Monday to Thursday: $(180-120)/120 = \mathbf{50\%}$. If each unit sells for Rs. 40, Friday's revenue: $165 \times 40 = \mathbf{Rs. 6,600}$. Three marks in under ninety seconds - because the arithmetic is Class 5 and only the reading is Class 10. Read the table's title and units first, every time.

Calendar and clock questions follow fixed formulas - the clock angle at 3:40 is $|30 \times 3 - 5.5 \times 40| = |90 - 220| = 130$ degrees - and a day-count question like 'today is Friday, what day is it after 61 days' is just $61 \bmod 7 = 5$, Friday + 5 = Wednesday. Learn the two formulas, drill five questions of each, and stop: these are two-question topics, not careers.

The eight traps that eat CBT-1 marks

- Percentage on the wrong base - a 25% markup followed by a 10% discount is not a 15% gain. Chain every percentage through its own base.
- Answering the wrong quantity - the question asks the ratio of ages in 5 years and you give it today. Underline what is asked before solving.
- Sign errors in boats and pipes - downstream adds the stream, upstream subtracts it; a leak is a negative filler.
- Reading a DI chart's axes backwards - ten seconds confirming the axes saves a whole wrong set.
- Unit blindness - a paper that mixes m/s and km/h is testing whether you convert before you compute.
- Solving what looks familiar - series and coding questions are often one twist away from the standard pattern; verify the twist on question 1 of its type, then speed up.
- Leaving the easy tail of a hard topic - the last two questions of a set are often the easiest marks in the paper once the setup is done.
- Fumbling squares and cubes under pressure - if 13 squared or 17 squared costs you three seconds of recall, drill the tables tonight.

The formula sheet worth an hour of your life

Copy this onto one card and keep it at your study desk; re-write it from memory on 1 November. Everything below is standard Class 8-10 material - but recall speed is what the 48-second clock demands.

Topic	What to memorise
Squares	1-25 ($21 \times 21 = 441$, $24 \times 24 = 576$ and similar traps)
Cubes	1-12 (plus 13 cubed = 2197, 15 cubed = 3375, 16 cubed = 4096)
Fraction-percent	$1/6 = 16.67\%$, $1/8 = 12.5\%$, $1/9 = 11.11\%$, $3/8 = 37.5\%$, $5/8 = 62.5\%$, $7/8 = 87.5\%$, $1/12 = 8.33\%$
Profit and loss	$SP = CP \times (1 \text{ plus or minus } p/100)$; equal profit and loss percent on fake CP; discount always on marked price
Interest	$SI = PRT/100$; Amount (CI) = $P(1 + r/100)^t$ to the power t; CI-SI for 2 years = $P(r/100)^2$ squared
Speed	km/h to m/s: $\times 5/18$; m/s to km/h: $\times 18/5$; average speed for equal distances = $2ab/(a+b)$
Time and work	Capacity = LCM of days; per-day work in units; pipes: fillers positive, leaks negative
Mensuration	Circle: πr^2 squared, $2\pi r$. Triangle: half base $\times$ height; Heron: root of $s(s-a)(s-b)(s-c)$. Cylinder: $\pi r^2 h$ squared h, CSA $2\pi r h$. Cone: third $\pi r^2 h$ squared h. Sphere: 4 thirds πr^3 cubed

Topic	What to memorise
Trigonometry	$\sin = \text{opposite/hypotenuse}$, $\cos = \text{adjacent/hypotenuse}$, $\tan = \text{opposite/adjacent}$; $\sin 30 = 1/2$, $\cos 60 = 1/2$, $\tan 45 = 1$
Clock	Angle = $ 30H - 5.5M $ degrees; hands coincide 11 times in 12 hours

7. The Reasoning playbook

Twenty-five questions and the highest section weight in the paper. It is also the cheapest section to improve in a short window, because reasoning questions are procedures, not knowledge: once you know the procedure, every question of that type falls. The official topic list:

Official CBT-1 Reasoning syllabus (CEN 01/2026, verbatim topics)

Analogies, Alphabetical and Number Series, Coding and Decoding, Mathematical operations, Relationships, Syllogism, Jumbling, Venn Diagram, Data Interpretation and Sufficiency, Conclusions and Decision Making, Similarities and Differences, Analytical reasoning, Classification, Directions, Statement - Arguments and Assumptions.

Number series

7, 11, 19, 35, ? - differences are 4, 8, 16, so the next difference is 32 and the answer is **67**. Two habits: always write the first difference row; if differences are not clean, check the ratio (x2 plus a constant is the other favourite).

Letter series

A, C, F, J, O, ? - positions are 1, 3, 6, 10, 15: gaps of +2, +3, +4, +5, so the next gap is +6 and the answer is position 21 = **U**. Write the alphabet with positions 1-26 at the top of your rough sheet before the section starts; half of verbal reasoning speed is just not counting on your fingers.

Coding-decoding

If TREE is written as USFF, each letter moves +1 (T-U, R-S, E-F, E-F). Then POND becomes **QPOE**. Variants to drill: reverse coding, positional-value coding (CAT = 3-1-20) and mixed arithmetic (letters jump by 2 then 3 alternately).

Analogy

Doctor : Hospital :: Teacher : ? - the relation is 'professional : workplace', so the answer is **School**. Test analogies with a spoken sentence linking the first pair, then apply the same sentence to the second. If two options fit, make the sentence stricter - order matters (A : B is not B : A).

Syllogism, solved with Venn diagrams

Statements: All engines are machines. Some machines are pumps. Conclusion: 'Some engines are pumps'? Draw the engine circle fully inside the machines circle; the pump circle only overlaps machines. The overlap could lie outside engines entirely - the conclusion **does not follow**. Never solve syllogisms by feel; draw the two or three possible diagrams and check the conclusion in all of them.

Venn diagram with numbers

In a class of 60, 35 like maths, 30 like science and 15 like both. Neither subject: $60 - (35 + 30 - 15) = 10$. Fill the 'both' region first, subtract outward, and total the regions to check they equal the universe. Almost every set question in this paper is this exact three-region structure.

Direction sense

A man walks 5 km north, then 3 km east, then 5 km south. He is exactly **3 km east** of his start point. Sketch a cross with N-E-S-W marked before reading the question - the north and south legs cancel, which is the whole trick.

Blood relations

Pointing to a photograph, Ram says, 'He is the son of my grandfather's only son.' The grandfather's only son is Ram's father; his son is Ram's brother - the photo is of **Ram's brother**. Decode one link at a time, forward from the speaker, and never let gender assumptions substitute for the sentence: 'only son' is what fixes the chain here.

Classification (odd one out)

27, 64, 125, 100: the first three are perfect cubes (3^3 , 4^3 , 5^3) and 100 is not - answer **100**. Odd-one-out questions are solved by elimination across four lenses in order: square/cube, divisibility, digit-sum pattern, and meaning (for words).

Seating puzzle, done in under a minute

Five friends P, Q, R, S, T sit in a row. R is exactly in the middle; P sits immediately right of R; T sits at an end next to no one but Q. Fix the frame first: T must occupy an end, say seat 1, with Q in seat 2; R is seat 3; P is seat 4; S takes **seat 5**. For any arrangement question, draw the slots, place the fixed elements first, and only then handle 'immediately-left/right' language - right means right from the persons facing you unless the question says they face you.

The rough-sheet system

Sixty minutes of reasoning on paper is a production process, and production processes need organisation. Divide your rough sheet into labelled columns before the section begins: one for series arithmetic (the difference row), one for letter positions (the 1-26 alphabet you have written out), one for Venn sketches, one for direction crosses. Write the question number beside every scrap of work so that in Round 2 you can reuse your own setup instead of starting cold. A tidy rough sheet is worth 3 to 5 questions an hour in a paper this fast - and if an invigilator ever questions your process, a labelled sheet is your friend.

For statement-argument and assumption questions, the scoring discipline is modesty: an argument is strong only if it directly addresses the proposal with a concrete reason; an assumption must be necessary for the statement to stand, not merely helpful. When in doubt, the answer that claims less is usually right. Jumbling and data-sufficiency questions reward the same patience - read the options first so you know exactly what you are testing before you test it.

8. The General Science playbook

Thirty questions, the largest single block in the paper, and - because it is 10th-standard Physics, Chemistry and Life Sciences - the most predictable. The CEN says it plainly: 'The syllabus under this shall cover Physics, Chemistry and Life Sciences of 10th standard level.' That sentence should make you happy, because it tells you exactly which books to open: NCERT Class 9 and 10 (or your state board equivalents).

How to cover three school years of science in five weeks

Not front-to-back. Triage the NCERT chapters into what the exam actually asks:

Subject	The chapters that pay	The habit
Physics	Motion, force and Newton's laws; work, energy and power; sound; light - reflection and refraction; electricity; magnetic effects; heat	Rewrite every law as: definition + SI unit + one example. One index card each.
Chemistry	Matter and its states; atoms and molecules; chemical reactions and equations; acids, bases and salts; metals and non-metals; carbon compounds	Maintain a formula-and-symbol sheet: common names, reaction types, pH scale.
Life Sciences	Life processes - nutrition, respiration, transport, excretion; control and coordination; reproduction; heredity and evolution; health and disease	Draw each process as a labelled flow diagram - the exam tests recognition, and diagrams build recognition.

The science section is won by recall speed, and recall speed is won by spaced revision: each evening, re-read the cards from two days earlier before starting new chapters. Practise science questions at the end of every study day, not after 'finishing' the syllabus - recognition needs testing, not re-reading.

The level you should expect (real examples)

SI unit of power: the watt. Ohm's law: a 12 V battery across a 4 ohm resistor drives $V/R = 3 \text{ A}$. The pH scale: values below 7 are acidic; a neutral salt solution sits near 7. Photosynthesis converts carbon dioxide and water into glucose using light energy trapped by chlorophyll, releasing oxygen. Haemoglobin in red blood cells carries oxygen. Light travels about 300,000 km per second. Every one of these is a Class 10 fact - which is precisely the point.

The physics fact bank (one evening to memorise)

Quantity	SI unit	Quantity	SI unit
Force	newton (N)	Current	ampere (A)
Work, energy	joule (J)	Charge	coulomb (C)
Power	watt (W)	Potential difference	volt (V)
Pressure	pascal (Pa)	Resistance	ohm
Frequency	hertz (Hz)	Power of lens	diopetre

Around that table sit the classic one-liners: acceleration due to gravity is about 9.8 metres per second squared; the speed of sound in air is roughly 330-340 m/s while light travels about 300,000 km per second, which is why thunder follows lightning; a convex lens converges light and a concave lens diverges it; a fuse protects a circuit by melting on overcurrent; electrical energy at home is measured in kilowatt-hours; one horsepower equals 746 watts; magnetic field lines run from the north pole to the south pole outside a magnet; and an ammeter connects in series while a voltmeter connects in parallel.

The chemistry fact bank: names, formulas, pH

Common name	Chemical name / formula
Common salt	Sodium chloride, NaCl
Washing soda	Sodium carbonate, $\text{Na}_2\text{CO}_3 \cdot 10\text{H}_2\text{O}$
Baking soda	Sodium hydrogencarbonate, NaHCO_3
Quicklime	Calcium oxide, CaO
Slaked lime	Calcium hydroxide, $\text{Ca}(\text{OH})_2$
Limestone, chalk, marble	Calcium carbonate, CaCO_3
Plaster of Paris	Calcium sulfate hemihydrate, $\text{CaSO}_4 \cdot \frac{1}{2}\text{H}_2\text{O}$
Glucose	$\text{C}_6\text{H}_{12}\text{O}_6$

Beside the table, hold these: acids turn blue litmus red and bases turn red litmus blue; the pH scale runs 0 to 14 with 7 neutral; a neutralisation reaction gives salt and water; rusting of iron needs both air and moisture and produces iron oxide; galvanisation is coating iron with zinc; and in a displacement reaction the more reactive metal pushes the less reactive one out of its compound - the reactivity series order (potassium, sodium, calcium, magnesium, aluminium, zinc, iron, lead, hydrogen, copper...) is worth ten minutes of recitation.

The life-science fact bank

- Photosynthesis: $6\text{CO}_2 + 6\text{H}_2\text{O}$, in sunlight with chlorophyll, gives $\text{C}_6\text{H}_{12}\text{O}_6 + 6\text{O}_2$ - the single most-quoted equation in railway exams.
- Xylem carries water and minerals up a plant; phloem carries food made in the leaves.
- The neuron is the structural and functional unit of the nervous system; reflex arcs bypass the brain for speed.
- Human blood: red cells carry oxygen via haemoglobin, white cells fight infection, platelets clot; plasma is the liquid part.
- Blood groups are classified by the ABO system and the Rh factor.
- Insulin from the pancreas lowers blood sugar; its deficiency causes diabetes.
- The thyroid needs iodine; deficiency causes goitre.
- Vitamin A: night blindness; B1: beriberi; C: scurvy; D: rickets - a two-by-two table worth memorising.
- The human heart has four chambers and doubles circulation: right side to the lungs, left side to the body.
- The liver is the largest gland; saliva contains amylase which begins starch digestion.
- Communicable diseases: cholera, tuberculosis, malaria (by mosquito), AIDS (by virus, spread through body fluids).

The rapid-revision sheet: 30 one-liners for the final week

In the last week you will not re-read NCERT. You will read this sheet, twice a day. Each line is one exam-ready fact from the Class 9-10 syllabus.

Physics	Chemistry and Life Sciences
Myopia (short sight) is corrected with a concave lens; hypermetropia with a convex lens.	Nitrogen is the most abundant gas in air, about 78%.

Physics	Chemistry and Life Sciences
An echo needs the reflector at least about 17 m away.	Hydrogen is the lightest element.
Human hearing spans roughly 20 Hz to 20,000 Hz.	Gold's chemical symbol is Au.
Ultrasound (above 20 kHz) is used in sonar and medical scans.	Water is called the universal solvent.
Convex mirrors give a wide field of view - hence rear-view mirrors.	Diamond is the hardest naturally occurring substance.
Concave mirrors focus light - hence torch reflectors and headlights.	Metal oxides are generally basic; non-metal oxides acidic.
A magnetic compass aligns along the north-south direction.	Methane (CH ₄) is a covalent compound.
A lightning conductor safely earths a strike.	Stainless steel is iron alloyed with chromium and nickel.
Work = force x displacement in the force's direction.	Chlorophyll sits inside chloroplasts.
Kinetic energy is half times mass times velocity squared.	Robert Hooke discovered the cell.
Power is work done per unit time.	The mitochondrion is the powerhouse of the cell.
A barometer measures atmospheric pressure.	The stapes in the middle ear is the smallest human bone.
White light splits into seven colours through a prism.	The skin is the largest organ of the human body.
White light splits into seven colours through a prism.	Malaria is caused by Plasmodium, spread by the female Anopheles mosquito.
Potential difference is measured by a voltmeter in parallel.	AIDS is caused by the virus HIV.

Bilingual bonus

The paper can be taken in Hindi and other regional languages, and many candidates find that technical science terms click faster in their stronger language. If you chose a regional language in the application, practise mocks in that language - do not train in English and fight in Hindi.

Books and materials: what is actually enough

You do not need a library. You need four things, and the discipline to finish them. One: NCERT Science for Classes 9 and 10 - the single source of the 30-question General Science section, read with the fact banks in section 8. Two: one standard railway exam mathematics and reasoning practice book, or a free question bank, for volume practice on the Tier-1 and Tier-2 topics - the reasoning section improves on repetition, not on theory. Three: previous-cycle RRB papers (ALP 2024, and NTPC or Group D CBT-1s for extra speed sets), because the difficulty and the question shapes carry over. Four: a mock series that follows the current 75-question, 60-minute, three-section pattern. That is all. Whatever you buy after this list is procrastination wearing a shopping bag.

9. The 39-day master plan

From today, 25 September, to the earliest exam date, 3 November, you have 39 full days. The plan below splits them into three phases with different jobs. Adjust the calendar to your own exam date once the city intimation link confirms it - but do not soften the structure.

Phase 1 SEPT 25 - OCT 10 16 days: complete the syllabus. Coverage with daily sectionals.	Phase 2 OCT 11 - OCT 25 15 days: the mock grind. Full mocks, analysis, repair.	Phase 3 OCT 26 - NOV 2 8 days: taper. Revision, error log, exam-shift rhythm.
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Phase 1: coverage, 25 September to 10 October

The job is simple and non-negotiable: touch every topic in all three sections once, with a 20-minute sectional quiz at the end of each day. Daily blocks: about 3 hours Mathematics, 2 hours Reasoning, 2 hours General Science, 30 minutes sectional quiz plus error notebook. The day-by-day grid:

Day	Mathematics (3h)	Reasoning (2h)	Science (2h)
1 - Sep 25	Number system, BODMAS, fractions	Analogies, classification, similarities	Motion, force, laws of motion
2	Decimals, LCM and HCF	Alphabetical series	Work, energy, power
3	Squares, roots, percentages basics	Number series	Sound; light - reflection
4	Percentage applications	Coding-decoding I	Light - refraction; human eye
5	Ratio and proportion, ages	Coding-decoding II, mathematical operations	Electricity: current, Ohm's law
6	Profit and loss	Blood relations	Magnetic effects; domestic circuits
7	Discount, successive change	Direction sense	Heat; revision of physics cards
8	Simple and compound interest	Syllogism I (Venn method)	Matter; atoms and molecules
9	Time and work	Syllogism II, Venn diagrams	Chemical reactions and equations
10	Pipes and cisterns	Data interpretation and sufficiency	Acids, bases and salts
11	Time, speed, distance - trains	Jumbling, sequencing	Metals and non-metals
12	Boats and streams, average speed	Statement - arguments, assumptions	Carbon and its compounds
13	Mensuration - 2D	Analytical puzzles I	Life processes I: nutrition, respiration
14	Mensuration - 3D	Analytical puzzles II	Life processes II: transport, excretion
15	Algebra; geometry and trigonometry basics	Full section revision	Control and coordination; reproduction
16 - Oct 10	Statistics, calendar and clock; baseline full mock	Mock analysis	Heredity, diseases; rapid-fire cards

Day 16 ends with your first full 75-question, 60-minute mock. Expect an ugly score - 40 to 50 is normal. Its only purpose is a map of your weakest ten topics; that map drives Phase 2.

Phase 2: the mock grind, 11 to 25 October

Fifteen days on a strict alternate-day cycle. Day A - full mock at a fixed morning hour, then the rest of the day on analysis under the 3:1 rule. Day B - repair: sectional practice on the topics the last mock exposed, plus a second pass at your two weakest Tier-1 maths topics and one reasoning type daily. Target progression: mock scores should climb from the 40s toward 60-plus by 25 October. If two mocks in a row stall at the same score, the problem is accuracy, not coverage - slow down, attempt fewer, hit 95%.

Day (Oct)	Cycle	Focus of the repair session
11 (A)	Full mock 2 + 3h analysis	Error log: classify every wrong question by topic
12 (B)	Repair	Weakest two maths topics from mock 2 + one reasoning type
13 (A)	Full mock 3 + analysis	Science sectional: 30 Q in 25 min
14 (B)	Repair	Speed drills: 20 calculations in 10 min; Venn and series sets
15 (A)	Full mock 4 + analysis	Compare section splits against mock 2 and 3
16 (B)	Repair	Mensuration and TSD second pass; syllogism diagrams
17 (A)	Full mock 5 + analysis	Halfway review: accuracy trend must be 85%+
18 (B)	Repair	Previous-cycle CBT-1 paper as sectional practice
19 (A)	Full mock 6 + analysis	Attempt-count experiment: cap attempts at 65
20 (B)	Repair	Weakest science chapters; rapid-fire fact cards
21 (A)	Full mock 7 + analysis	Time-split review per section
22 (B)	Repair	All error-log entries re-solved from mocks 2-7
23 (A)	Full mock 8 + analysis	Target: 55+ raw with 90% accuracy
24 (B)	Repair	Formula sheet rewrite from memory
25 (A)	Full mock 9 + analysis	Decide final section order for exam day

The 3:1 rule

For every one hour of mock, spend three on analysis. A 60-minute mock deserves a three-hour post-mortem: every wrong answer gets a line in the error log (topic, why I got it wrong, the fix), every guess gets the same, and every skipped question gets classified as 'could not' or 'ran out of time'. The mock is the diagnosis; the analysis is the cure. Candidates who skip analysis improve on hope, not evidence.

If you are starting from zero today

Compress coverage brutally: Tier-1 maths topics, series-coding-syllogism-direction reasoning, and the science fact banks in section 8 - skip Tier-3 entirely except the clock and calendar formulas. Run your first mock on day 10, not day 16. Aim for the honest 55-60 band rather than the 62 target, and accept that a full-syllabus second pass is a luxury you no longer have. Done with discipline, a 50-plus score in 39 days from a standing start is entirely realistic.

If the city intimation gives you 4 or 5 November instead of 3 November, shift every phase right by one or two days - but keep the final taper day immediately before your own exam date, whatever it is. The plan flexes; the structure does not.

Phase 3: the taper, 26 October to 2 November

Day	The plan
Oct 26	Mock 10 in the morning at your likely shift hour; light error-log revision only after noon.
Oct 27	Re-solve every twice-failed error-log entry; science rapid-fire cards; early night.
Oct 28	Mock 11; revise the formula sheet and fact banks end to end.
Oct 29	City intimation link expected live - download it, plan travel, book nothing non-refundable.
Oct 30	Mock 12 (last full mock); write the formula sheet from memory and mark the gaps.
Oct 31	Light revision only: your one-page sheets, no new material; e-call letter expected today or tomorrow - download and print two copies.
Nov 1	Documents check: call letter, Aadhaar, photo. Route-plan to the centre. Sleep at exam hours.
Nov 2	One-hour light revision in the morning. No mocks. Prepare clothes and bag. Sleep early.

Three daily schedules - pick the one that is yours

Block	Full-time aspirant (7-8 h)	Working candidate (4-4.5 h)	With family duties (5 h, split)
Early morning	Maths 3h fresh-mind block	Maths 1.5h before work	Maths 2h before the house wakes
Midday	Science 2h + lunch	- (work)	Science 1.5h
Evening	Reasoning 2h	Reasoning 1.5h after work	Reasoning 1h + 30 min quiz
Night	Sectional quiz + error log 1h	Science 1h + quiz 30 min	Error log 30 min
Weekend	One full mock + analysis (3:1 rule)	Full mock + analysis, twice a weekend	Full mock + analysis on both days

The taper is not optional garnish. A 60-minute speed test rewards a rested brain more than one more chapter of heredity. Candidates who peak on 30 October and burn the last three nights on fresh material routinely hand back 5 marks on exam day.

10. Mock tests and the error log

A mock is worthless without a scoring record and an error log. Keep both in one notebook, one page per mock, in this exact shape:

Column	What goes in it
Attempted / Correct / Wrong	The three raw numbers, plus accuracy percentage
Section split	Maths, Reasoning, Science: correct out of the section total
Time split	Minutes spent per section versus planned
Errors	For each wrong question: topic, error type (concept / calculation / speed / guess), the fix in one line
Skips	Topic of every unattempted question and why
Next-mock rule	One concrete behaviour change for the next mock, written before you close the notebook

A sample page, so you never have to invent the format

Mock 4 - 15 Oct	Maths	Reasoning	Science	Total
Attempted	17	22	26	65
Correct	14	19	24	57
Wrong	3	3	2	8
Accuracy	82%	86%	92%	88%
Time (min)	26	18	14	58

Sample error-log lines from that mock: 'Mensuration - cone CSA vs volume confused - rewrite formula card tonight'; 'Syllogism - concluded 'some' from 'all + some' - redo Venn drill set 4'; 'Clock - spent 2.5 min on one angle question - hard 60-second cap'. Sample next-mock rule: 'Cap Maths at 25 minutes; skip anything past 60 seconds.'

The weekly progress tracker

Print this or copy it into the front of your notebook. One line per week, filled every Sunday night after the week's last mock. It is the simplest honest answer to 'am I on track?' - the trend column either climbs toward your 62-target or it does not.

Week ending	Best mock	Accuracy	Weakest section	One fix for next week
4 October				
11 October				
18 October				

Week ending	Best mock	Accuracy	Weakest section	One fix for next week
25 October				
1 November				

Track the accuracy trend, not just the score. A candidate moving from 48 (78% accuracy) to 54 (93% accuracy) is on the winning path; a candidate jumping 48 to 58 on 70% accuracy is building a house on guesswork that the real exam's negative marking will tax. Use previous-cycle CBT-1 papers (the 2024 ALP paper circulates widely through coaching platforms) as at least two of your mocks - they calibrate real difficulty better than any publisher's ambition. When you buy or download mocks, verify they follow the current pattern: 75 questions, 60 minutes, three sections, no General Awareness.

11. Exam-day battle plan

Before you leave home

- Printed e-call letter (colour or black-and-white, as specified), an original photo ID - Aadhaar is the safest because the RRB uses Aadhaar-linked biometric authentication at the centre - and a recent passport-size photograph.
- Keep your Aadhaar e-KYC status in order; if your biometric fails to verify, follow the centre's manual-verification process calmly rather than arguing at the gate.
- Nothing electronic: no phone, no smartwatch, no bluetooth. Wear simple clothing without metal-heavy accessories.
- Leave for the centre early enough to arrive well before the reporting time printed on the call letter; gates close firmly.
- Eat something familiar. Do not experiment with breakfast on the one morning that matters.

Inside the 60 minutes

Play the paper in three rounds, not one linear crawl:

Round	Time	What you do
Round 1	0 - 35 min	Sweep the whole paper section by section in your strongest order. Take every question you can answer in under 40 seconds. Flag the rest; skip the visibly long ones.
Round 2	35 - 53 min	Second pass on flagged questions - the calculation-heavy maths and the reasoning puzzles you parked.
Round 3	53 - 60 min	Only for questions where you can eliminate two options. Never blind-guess: with a 1/3 penalty and four options, a pure guess is worth nothing on average - and it burns seconds you could spend verifying an answer you already own.

Section order that suits most candidates

General Science first - these are recognition questions answered fastest while the mind is fresh and they bank 30 easy potential marks. Reasoning second, when pattern-spotting is warm. Mathematics last, where time pressure concentrates naturally on the section that most needs it. If your profile is inverted, invert the order - but decide it in Phase 2 mocks, not in the exam hall.

One habit worth more than any technique: when a question passes 60 seconds without progress, flag and leave. Every year, capable candidates lose a whole section's worth of marks because one puzzle held them hostage.

The ten mistakes that cost real marks every shift

- Arriving at the right time at the wrong address - centres have multiple gates; the call letter's gate is the only one that matters.
- Panic on question one. If it resists, move; the paper does not begin at the beginning.
- Not reading the on-screen instructions about the marking scheme - the 1/3 rule is also printed there; the paper matches this playbook, but read it anyway.
- Spending the first three minutes on the hardest reasoning set because it appeared first.
- Changing answers in the last five minutes without a reason - your first instinct, when informed, beats cold re-solving under the clock.
- Skipping the easy last questions of a set after investing in its setup - collect the full return on your setup time.
- Losing count of the clock - glance at the timer at the 20-minute and 40-minute marks, not continuously.
- Filling the on-screen answers late - the interface records what is marked at time-out, not what you meant.
- Discussing the paper at the gate and letting a friend's confident wrong answer eat at you for the drive home.
- Treating CBT-1 as the destination - it is the turnstile. The seat is decided later, by CBT-2 Part A and CBAT.

A worked 60 minutes: how a 63 unfolds

To make the rounds concrete, here is how a strong paper actually flows for a candidate who attempts 70 questions with 93% accuracy - a 63 after negative marking, which clears every zone in the last cycle's table:

Clock	What happens
0 - 2 min	Instructions skimmed, timer checked, one slow breath. Rough sheet columns labelled.
2 - 14 min	Science sweep: 26 of 30 attempted, 3 hard ones flagged, 1 left for good. About 22 banked.
14 - 30 min	Reasoning first pass: 19 of 25 attempted; two puzzles flagged for Round 2. About 41 banked.
30 - 36 min	Mathematics quick harvest: 12 of 20 attempted - the percentage, ratio and series questions that fall in under 40 seconds.
36 - 50 min	Round 2: returns to the flagged science, both puzzles, and the four mid-length maths questions. Attempts now 68.
50 - 56 min	Two questions narrowed to two options each - taken. Two abandoned on the 60-second rule. Attempts 70.
56 - 60 min	No new questions. Check the interface shows every answer marked, verify three earlier answers that felt hurried.

Notice what the story does not contain: heroics, a 90-second struggle, or a blind guess. Seventy attempts at 93% accuracy is simply the compound interest of leaving questions at 60 seconds and never guessing cold.

If something goes wrong at the centre

If your system hangs or the interface freezes, raise your hand immediately - the invigilator logs the incident and the clock is handled per RRB procedure; the time is not simply lost. If you feel unwell, report it before the test starts, not after. And if the biometric gate trips twice, ask calmly for the alternate verification process rather than allowing panic into the last minutes before your 60. Whatever the disruption, the rule is the same: report, record, resume.

12. Self-test: 36 questions to calibrate yourself

Sit this test at the end of Phase 1 - 85 minutes, no calculator, no breaks, the answer key face-down until you finish. Score it without mercy: 24 or better out of 36 (67%) means you are on track for the mid-50s raw score that most zones demand; below 18 means your Phase 2 must add a second pass through your weakest section, not just mocks. Every question sits at genuine CBT-1 difficulty - if you can do these quickly, the paper holds no surprises for you.

Mathematics (12 questions, 30 minutes)

- 1 What is 35% of 480?
- 2 A train 150 m long crosses a pole in 9 seconds. What is its speed in km/h?
- 3 What is the LCM of 24 and 36?
- 4 A sum of money doubles itself in 8 years at simple interest. What is the rate of interest per annum?
- 5 A shopkeeper sells an article for Rs. 690 at a profit of 15%. What was the cost price?
- 6 A can finish a piece of work in 15 days and B in 10 days. Working together, how many days do they need?
- 7 The average of five consecutive even numbers is 24. What is the largest of them?
- 8 If 3 pens and 5 notebooks cost Rs. 195, while 3 pens and 2 notebooks cost Rs. 120, what is the price of one notebook?
- 9 If 12 pens cost the same as 6 notebooks, and a pen costs Rs. 15, what does a notebook cost?
- 10 What is the compound interest on Rs. 8,000 at 10% per annum for 2 years?
- 11 Two numbers are in the ratio 5:7 and their sum is 96. What is the larger number?
- 12 A workshop produces 120, 150, 135, 180 and 165 units from Monday to Friday. What is the average daily production?

Reasoning (12 questions, 30 minutes)

- 1 Complete the series: 2, 6, 12, 20, 30, ?
- 2 Complete the series: AZ, BY, CX, ?
- 3 If FLOWER is coded as GMPXFS, how is GARDEN coded?
- 4 A is the sister of B. C is the mother of B. D is the father of C. How is A related to D?
- 5 Find the odd one out: 121, 144, 169, 190.
- 6 Statements: All pens are books. All books are copies. Conclusion: All pens are copies - does it follow?
- 7 In a row of 40 students, Amit is 12th from the left end. What is his position from the right end?
- 8 Ravi faces north, turns 90 degrees right, then another 90 degrees right, then 90 degrees left. Which direction is he facing now?
- 9 If MOUSE is coded as PRXVH, how is SHIFT coded?
- 10 Pointing to a man, Sita says, "He is the brother of my mother." How is the man related to Sita?

11 Find the odd one out: 3, 5, 11, 14, 17.

12 In a row of five seats, R is at the left end, T at the right end, S sits between Q and T, and P is immediately left of Q. Who sits in the middle seat?

General Science (12 questions, 25 minutes)

1 What is the chemical formula of quicklime?

2 Deficiency of which vitamin causes scurvy?

3 What is the SI unit of electric charge?

4 Which organ of the human body produces insulin?

5 Which gas do plants absorb during photosynthesis?

6 One horsepower equals approximately how many watts?

7 Which blood cells help the body fight infection?

8 What is the pH of a neutral solution at 25 degrees Celsius?

9 How many bones are there in the adult human body?

10 Which acid is present in the human stomach?

11 The conversion of water vapour into liquid is called what?

12 Which of Newton's laws states that force equals mass times acceleration?

Answer key with one-line solutions

No.	Answer	The one-line route
M1	168	$10\% \text{ of } 480 = 48; 5\% = 24; 35\% = 3 \times 48 + 24 = 168.$
M2	60 km/h	$150/9 = 16.67 \text{ m/s}; \times 18/5 = 60.$
M3	72	$24 = 2 \times 2 \times 2 \times 3; 36 = 2 \times 2 \times 3 \times 3; \text{ take highest powers: } 72.$
M4	12.5%	SI = P over 8 years means 100% in 8 years = 12.5% per year.
M5	Rs. 600	$690 / 1.15 = 600.$
M6	6 days	Capacity 30 units: A does 2/day, B does 3/day; $30/5 = 6.$
M7	28	The middle number is 24; the five are 20, 22, 24, 26, 28.
M8	Rs. 25	Subtract: 3 notebooks = 75, so one = 25.
R1	42	Differences grow 4, 6, 8, 10, then 12: $30 + 12.$
R2	DW	First letters A, B, C then D; last letters Z, Y, X then W.
R3	HBSEFO	Each letter moves +1: G-H, A-B, R-S, D-E, E-F, N-O.
R4	Granddaughter	C is A's mother; D is C's father, hence A's grandfather.
R5	190	121, 144, 169 are perfect squares (11, 12, 13); 190 is not.
R6	Follows	All pens sit inside books, which sit inside copies - the chain transmits.
R7	29th	$40 - 12 + 1 = 29.$
R8	East	North -right-> East -right-> South -left-> East.
S1	CaO	Calcium oxide, quicklime.
S2	Vitamin C	Ascorbic acid; its absence causes scurvy.
S3	Coulomb	One coulomb = charge carried by one ampere in one second.
S4	Pancreas	Insulin from the pancreas regulates blood sugar.
S5	Carbon dioxide	$6\text{CO}_2 + 6\text{H}_2\text{O}$ give glucose and oxygen, in sunlight.
S6	746 watts	1 hp = 746 W.
S7	White blood cells	WBCs (leucocytes) fight infection.
S8	7	Below 7 acidic, above 7 basic, 7 neutral.
M9	Rs. 30	12 pens = $12 \times 15 = \text{Rs. } 180$; each notebook = $180/6 = 30.$
M10	Rs. 1,680	$8000 \times (1.1 \times 1.1 - 1) = 8000 \times 0.21.$
M11	56	One part = $96/12 = 8$; larger = $7 \times 8.$
M12	150 units	750 total / 5 days.
R9	VKLIW	Each letter moves +3: S-V, H-K, I-L, F-I, T-W.
R10	Maternal uncle	Mother's brother.
R11	14	3, 5, 11, 17 are primes; 14 is not.
R12	Q	Seats: R, P, Q, S, T from left - S sits between Q and T, P is immediately left of Q.
S9	206	The adult human skeleton has 206 bones.
S10	Hydrochloric acid	HCl in the gastric juice.
S11	Condensation	Vapour to liquid - the reverse of evaporation.
S12	Second law	$F = ma.$

How to read your score

30-36: you are already in shortlist shape - spend Phase 2 purely on speed and mock discipline. 24-29: solid base; the gap is one section, and your error log will name it. 18-23: cover the syllabus a second time before adding mocks; mocks on an incomplete base only rehearse mistakes. Below 18: still very fixable in 39 days - rebuild from the NCERT and Tier-1 basics, and re-sit this test on 10 October.

13. After the exam: CBT-2, CBAT, DV and the medical

In the previous cycle, CBT-1 ran in late November 2024 and results arrived at the end of February 2025. Expect a similar multi-month wait, with the answer key and a response-sheet window before the result. Whatever you do, do not stop studying while you wait - the candidates who clear CBT-1 comfortably are the ones who used the gap.

CBT-2: the stage that decides half your merit

CBT-2 has two parts in one sitting of 2 hours 30 minutes. Part A is 100 questions in 90 minutes across Mathematics, General Intelligence and Reasoning, and Basic Science and Engineering (engineering drawing, units and measurements, mass-weight-density, work-power-energy, speed-velocity, heat-temperature, basic electricity, levers and simple machines, occupational safety, environment education and IT literacy). Part B is 75 questions in 60 minutes from the trade syllabus prescribed by the Directorate General of Training - your ITI trade, or for diploma and degree holders, the trade mapped to your engineering discipline. Part B is qualifying: 35% for every candidate with no community relaxation. Negative marking is 1/3 in both parts.

The CEN maps diploma and degree holders to trade groups; the shape of the mapping is below. Whatever your branch, the authoritative list is in the CEN and the DGT trade syllabi at dgt.gov.in.

Your qualification	Typical Part-B trade group
Electrical / Electronics / combination streams	Electrician, Instrument Mechanic, Electronics Mechanic, Mechanic Radio and TV, Wireman, Armature and Coil Winder, Refrigeration and AC Mechanic
Mechanical / combination streams	Fitter, Turner, Machinist, Mechanic Motor Vehicle, Tractor Mechanic, Mechanic Diesel, Heat Engine, Millwright / Maintenance Mechanic, Refrigeration and AC Mechanic
Automobile streams	Mechanic Motor Vehicle, Tractor Mechanic, Mechanic Diesel, Heat Engine, Refrigeration and AC Mechanic
ITI / Act Apprenticeship	The trade you qualified in, as named in your application

Practical advice for the gap: start Part-B trade revision early. It is the stage where working electricians and fitters outscore bright generalists, precisely because it rewards their daily craft. If you are from a diploma background, get the DGT trade syllabus for your mapped trade and work through it once before CBT-2 even appears on the horizon.

CBAT: the other half of your merit

About eight candidates per vacancy reach the Computer Based Aptitude Test - five batteries covering memory, following directions, depth perception, concentration and perceptual speed. There is no negative marking; the medium is only English and Hindi; and you need a minimum T-score of 42 in each battery to qualify. The final merit is 50% CBT-2 Part A and 50% CBAT. Practice materials for aptitude batteries are widely available - speed and calm, not knowledge, are what they test, so sleep before CBAT is preparation.

How to practise the five batteries, once CBT-2 is behind you: memory - read eight-digit number strings and recall them a minute later; following directions - solve instruction-sequence puzzles where each step changes the previous state; depth perception and concentration - use any timed dot-matching or figure-matching drill; perceptual speed - short, fast symbol-matching sprints of 2

minutes each. The CEN itself points to the RDSO website for CBAT information - that is the authoritative place to see sample test descriptions. A calm, slept, practised candidate scores; a caffeinated, anxious one usually does not.

Document verification: the paperwork that ends careers

Carry originals (plus two self-attested copies)	Why
Matriculation certificate	Proof of date of birth - the RRB goes by this, not by horoscopes or affidavits
ITI NCVT/SCVT certificates and marksheets, or Diploma/Degree certificates and marksheets	The educational qualification you claimed
Community certificate (SC/ST/OBC-NCL) issued by the competent authority	For reserved-category claims, in the format the CEN asks for
EWS certificate, where applicable	Must be valid for the current financial year as the CEN specifies
Ex-servicemen / apprenticeship documents, if claimed	Discharge book, NAS certificate for apprentices
Photo ID, photographs, and the call-letter set for every stage	Identity at DV and the medical

The medical exam is the A-1 standard - the strictest in Indian Railways, built around high visual acuity including colour and night vision for running duty. Get a preliminary eye check now if you have any doubt; candidates found medically unsuitable for ALP are not offered an alternate post.

14. The last 24 hours: runbook and checklists

Everything you need to hold in your head at the end has been written down above. The last day has one job: arrive at the centre rested, documented and on time. This is the runbook.

The evening before (whichever day your exam is)

- 1 Close the books by 8 p.m. Whatever is not in your head by now is not going in tonight.
- 2 Re-read only your one-page formula sheet and the science fact banks - recognition, not learning.
- 3 Pack: printed e-call letter (two copies), Aadhaar card (and one more original photo ID as backup), two passport photos, a water bottle if the call letter allows it.
- 4 Check the reporting time and centre address again from the call letter itself, not from memory or a friend's message.
- 5 Set two alarms. Sleep at the hour that lets you wake four hours before your shift.

The morning of the exam

- 1 Wake, eat a familiar breakfast, and do one 10-question warm-up set - light, just to switch the brain on.
- 2 Leave with a 60-minute cushion over your planned travel time.
- 3 At the gate: biometric verification, frisking, seating. Follow instructions exactly; switch off mentally, not just your devices.
- 4 Before you click start: 30 seconds of slow breathing. Sixty minutes later, 39 days of work gets one hour to speak.

The 60-second self-check before you click Start

75 questions. 60 minutes. Science first (or your chosen order). 60-second cap per question. Guess only after eliminating two options. That is the whole plan - everything else is execution.

15. The cut-out exam-day card

Everything that matters on the morning of 3, 4 or 5 November, on one page. Photograph it, print it, or copy it onto the back page of your notebook - and do not re-derive any of it in the exam hall.

Documents

Printed e-call letter (two copies). Original Aadhaar (photo ID). One recent passport photograph. Nothing electronic on your body. Arrive well before the reporting time printed on the call letter - the gate does not negotiate.

The three rounds

Round 1, minutes 0-35: sweep everything answerable in under 40 seconds, Science - Reasoning - Maths. Round 2, minutes 35-53: return to flagged questions. Round 3, minutes 53-60: only questions narrowed to two options; verify the interface shows every answer marked. Hard cap: 60 seconds per question, then flag and move.

The numbers to hold in your head

75 questions. 60 minutes. Plus 1, minus one-third. Attempt 60-68 at 90%+ accuracy. Section target: 14/20 Maths, 20/25 Reasoning, 27/30 Science = 61 before normalization. Qualifying floor: UR/EWS 30 marks, OBC/SC 22.5, ST 18.75. Personal target: 62 - higher if your zone is Patna, Muzaffarpur or Gorakhpur.

Mind

You have prepared 39 days for 60 minutes. Rested beats revised. Do not discuss the paper at the gate. Do not chase the friend who 'found it easy' - normalization has not finished its work. Walk out, go home, sleep.

16. Stay safe: scams, agents and official links

Every railway recruitment season grows a crop of frauds: agents promising question papers, 'guaranteed selection' packages, fake admit-card sites that harvest your registration details, and calls asking for money to 'confirm' your exam city. None of it is real. The RRBs never charge for anything beyond the application fee, never sell preparation material, and never appoint agents. Your fee refund after appearing in CBT-1 - Rs. 400 of the Rs. 500 for general candidates, and the full Rs. 250 for concession categories, minus bank charges - arrives on its own; nobody can speed it up for a fee.

- Everything official lives on your chosen RRB's website and rrbapply.gov.in - links to all RRBs are on indianrailways.gov.in.
- Report offers of leaked papers to the RRB and the police; at minimum, never pay.
- Never share your registration number, date of birth and OTPs together with anyone - that combination is your login.
- Admit cards are downloaded by you, never emailed as attachments by 'the RRB'.

17. Frequently asked questions

Is there an interview after CBAT?

No. For Assistant Loco Pilot the selection is complete at CBT-2 and CBAT, followed by document verification and the medical examination. There is no interview stage.

When will CBT-2 and CBAT happen?

Unannounced. For calibration: in the previous cycle, CBT-1 ran in late November 2024, results came in late February 2025, and CBT-2 followed in March 2025 - roughly four months from CBT-1 to CBT-2. Assume a similar rhythm, and prepare Part A and your trade in that window.

How many candidates will be shortlisted from my zone?

About 15 times your zone's vacancies for CBT-2, computed RRB-wise and community-wise on normalized CBT-1 marks. That is why your zone's vacancy count - section 1 - sets your local competition, not the national total.

Which books are enough?

NCERT 9-10 science, one standard maths-reasoning practice book for volume, previous-cycle RRB papers, and a current-pattern mock series. The full reasoning is in section 9 - more material than that is avoidance, not preparation.

Is the 3-5 November exam window final?

It is the official tentative schedule from the RRB notice dated 21 September 2026. Treat it as real, watch the RRB websites for any change, and prepare for the earliest date.

I also applied for RRB Technician CEN 02/2026, whose CBT is on 6-9 October. Can I prepare for both?

Yes - the CBT-1 subjects overlap almost completely. The Technician paper is a single CBT; sit it, then continue this plan for ALP. Your energy should shift to ALP as soon as the Technician shift is done.

When will the CBT-1 result come?

Unannounced. The previous cycle took about three months from exam to result. Use the window for CBT-2 Part-A and trade preparation, not for refreshing result pages.

I answered in Hindi. Is that a disadvantage?

No. The paper is offered in Hindi and regional languages as listed in the CEN, and normalization does not penalise language choice. Practise mocks in the language you will write the exam in.

What is a good number of attempts in 60 minutes?

60 to 68 attempts with 90%+ accuracy is the sweet spot. Below 55 attempts you are leaving marks on the table; above 68 you are usually guessing, and the 1/3 penalty taxes exactly that.

Do CBT-1 marks count in the final selection?

No. CBT-1 only shortlists you for CBT-2; the final panel is built from CBT-2 Part A (50%) and CBAT (50%). Clear it decisively, then treat it as forgotten.

My application status says 'conditionally accepted'. Should I worry?

Check the reason in your rrbapply.gov.in login and fix whatever document or detail is flagged, following the instructions given. Do not wait for the exam week to resolve it.

I am working full-time. Can I still do this plan?

Compress Phase 1 into evening blocks (2 hours maths, 1.5 reasoning, 1.5 science daily) and use weekends for coverage of Tier-3 topics and every alternate-day mock. The phases keep their order; only their length changes.

Which calculator or rough sheet is allowed?

No calculator, ever. Rough sheets are provided at the centre and collected after - practise mental arithmetic and clean written work in every mock so that rough-sheet speed is already your habit.

What if I miss the cutoff by a mark?

Then the cycle is over for this CEN and you are better prepared for the next one - but do not budget for missing by a mark. Budget for the 62-target, the strongest zone's 68, and let the margin do its work.

The final word

Thirty-nine days is enough time to change your result, not enough time to change your preparation philosophy. So keep one: coverage before depth, accuracy before attempts, analysis before volume, sleep before one more chapter. The railway does not need the smartest candidate on 3 November. It needs the steadiest one for sixty minutes. Walk in rested, play your rounds, and let the 39 days do their work.

18. Glossary: the language of railway recruitment

The RRBs write everything in a compressed official shorthand. Here is what every abbreviation in this playbook means, in one table you can return to whenever a notice lands.

Term	What it means
CEN	Centralised Employment Notice - the master recruitment notification. This cycle is CEN No. 01/2026 for Assistant Loco Pilot.
CBT	Computer Based Test, conducted at a physical exam centre on a computer terminal. CBT-1 screens; CBT-2 scores the merit.
CBAT	Computer Based Aptitude Test - the five-battery psychometric stage for ALP, qualifying in nature with a T-score 42 bar.
T-score	The standardized score CBAT batteries are reported in, scaled so that 42 is the qualifying floor in each battery.
Normalization	The statistical adjustment of raw scores across shifts so that easier and harder shifts are treated fairly.
Shortlisting ratio	How many candidates per vacancy advance: about 15x for CBT-2, about 8x for CBAT, computed RRB-wise and community-wise.
E-call letter	The electronic admit card, downloadable from the RRB websites about 4 days before your exam date.
City intimation	The advance slip revealing your exam city and date, about 10 days before the exam. It is not the admit card.
DV	Document Verification - the original-certificates stage after CBAT.
A-1 medical standard	The strictest railway medical category, required for running-duty posts like ALP; built around high visual acuity and colour vision.
DGT	Directorate General of Training - the agency whose ITI trade syllabi define CBT-2 Part B.
NCVT / SCVT	National and State Councils for Vocational Training - the recognising bodies for ITI certificates.
Pay Level-2	The 7th Pay Commission grade for ALP, with initial basic pay of Rs. 19,900 before allowances.
rrbapply.gov.in	The single online application portal used by all RRBs - where your login, status and downloads live.

Sources and verification

Every date, rule and figure in this playbook was verified in September 2026 from the following: the detailed Centralised Employment Notice CEN No. 01/2026 (Assistant Loco Pilot) published on the official websites of the Railway Recruitment Boards; the RRB notice regarding the tentative CBT-1 schedule dated 21 September 2026; official zone-wise CBT-1 result and cutoff documents for CEN No. 01/2024 published by the RRBs in February 2025; and reporting of the RRB notices by The Times of India, Jagran Josh and Testbook. The applicant count of 8,40,944 is as reported for CEN 01/2026 applications.

This is an independent study guide. It is not published by, affiliated with or endorsed by the Railway Recruitment Boards, Indian Railways or the Government of India. Exam dates are tentative per the RRB notice and can change; always confirm current information on the official RRB websites and rrbapply.gov.in.